

Assignment on MM as historian and contemporary cultural critic.

--Bonnie Costello

Moore as historian and contemporary cultural critic:
In teaching "The Jerboa" I like to show students how the references to ancient Egypt and biblical lands connect to contemporary issues. I use images from the excavation of King Tut's tomb (some of these are in the MM Newsletter). I introduce relevant passages from Genesis (the story of Esau/Jacob and the birthright; the pillow of stones and the wrestling with the angel), but then shift to the modern world. The Aswan Dam was under construction (the British were raising the level of the Lower Dam in 1929-32). Jim Crow laws were curtailing the freedom and opportunity of African-Americans. And of course the Great Depression was deepening, leaving many in desperate poverty and making a stark contrast with the conspicuous consumption of the Gilded Age. How does Moore manage to provide social commentary and critique without didacticism or documentary protest?